

IN HER THEY TRUST
Anar Patel, daughter of former Gujarat CM Anandiben Patel

believes his aligning with one party can dent the community's political pelf," says a Patidar community leader in the BJP. Now, Anar's elevation contains the implicit signal of an apparent leaning towards the BJP.

Even so, it's a measured step within a bipartisan setup. Along with Anar's elevation, Jenny Thummar, a second-generation Congress leader from Amreli, has been appointed a trustee. Another trustee, Ramesh Tilala, is a BJP MLA from Rajkot South; at least six among the 50-odd trustees have contested on BJP and Congress tickets.

THE UNFINISHED STORY

That fact completes a poetic metre left interrupted a decade ago. It was in 2016 that Anandiben, presently the governor of Uttar Pradesh, had her term as Gujarat's first woman chief minister suddenly terminated—less than two years into her job. Publicly, the pink slip was ascribed to her inability to rein in the Patidar agitation led by Hardik Patel; politically, it was blamed on factionalism within the BJP. Anar, once seen as a rising political star, had then taken a backseat. She still claims she "does not like politics". But sources in the BJP believe this seat at the high table is as valuable as any fruit of electoral politics.

Takeaways

- **Former CM Anandiben Patel's daughter, Anar, is a social entrepreneur who "does not like politics"**
- **But the Khodaldham Trust influences choice of candidates in at least half of Gujarat's assembly seats**

Mild-natured, congenial and articulate, Anar is a popular figure in Gujarat's arts and crafts circuit. Her social entrepreneurship is best captured in her NGOs Craftsroots and Gramshree, which engage thousands of women at the grassroots across the state, besides work in education. Having joined the trust in 2017, she has also led its women's wing for three years.

Personally, she still disavows any leaning towards politics. "This is not an ordinary post but a great responsibility, and I am fully conscious of it. Patidars have strength, wealth, but true strength lies in unity," she said at the Khodaldham Organisation Convenor Meet 2026 in Kagvad town near Rajkot, where the announcement was made in late January. "I have not been given this responsibility to enter politics or for a ticket; it is solely to strengthen Patidar unity and expand the organisation," she said.

'UNIFIED COMMUNITY'

Yet, a purely apolitical reading would miss the context entirely: Gujarat's assembly election is scheduled for December 2027, while polls to 16 municipal corporations will be announced as soon as the ongoing SIR exercise concludes. Within this competitive space, the Khodaldham Trust operates on the simple principle of 'united we stand'. Commanding the allegiance of the affluent community across the globe, the institution prevails on all parties in candidate selection and ensures a maximum of Patidar leaders are fielded.

So, despite its stated distance from active politics, it influences the choice of candidates in about half of Gujarat's 182-seat assembly. As a unified business community voice thereafter, it also deeply influences government policy. Being at the helm of such a body, one could say, offers the unique opportunity to integrate community welfare with political needs in a tacit convergence.

It is into such a role that Anar has come—a power centre sans any doubt, that too in a state where power flows vicariously owing to its larger-than-life absentee landlords in New Delhi. The new state BJP president Jagdish Vishwakarma and deputy chief minister Harsh Sanghvi, besides chief minister Bhupendra Patel, represent the local power points, with Union home minister and Gandhinagar MP Amit Shah dominating the space with his loyalists. Anar's arrival brings a new axis. ■